

Dik'alt'iy (lesson seven)***Warm-up writing practice***

'fish'

'his fish'

'saliva'

'my saliva'

'scab'

'her scab'

'it's scabby'

'Your anus will become scabby.' (said if you eat something you have given away)

 or

Conjunct prefix u- ~ w- ~ o-

Here is some review of **u** vs. **w** from the first literacy class:

uzi	'name'
wizi	'in the dark', as in wizi tēstkiy 'it's getting dark'
unis	'way out'
Unistot'en	'Witsuwit'en people who live south of Houston'
winis	'more, than'
winis 'ilco	'it's bigger'
uye	'shy'
wiye wewiwhldzin	'don't make noise (you pl.)'

Sometimes **u** is part of the formula for a verb. This **u** regularly becomes **w** when followed by two syllables which begin with a consonant. In the first example of each group, **u** is followed by exactly one syllable, and in the rightmost column, **w** is followed by two or more syllables.

weugeh	'he/she isn't shy'
wewdīt'ën	'it's marked, signed'
deut'ën?	'what does it look like?'
dewnīt'ën?	'what does his/her face look like?'
neundzih	'call his name again'
neundzi	'you called his name again'
newtandzilh	'you'll call his name again'
uldiw	'count it'
neuldiw	'count it again'
newtaldiw	'she'll count it again'

In other forms of verbs, **u** regularly becomes **o**, after one of the following consonants:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	'
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

Compare:

uszi	'I'm calling his name'
ts'ozı	'we're calling his name'
yuzı	'she's calling his name'
hibuzı	'she's calling their names'
sozi	'she's calling my name'
nyuzı	'he's calling your name'
niwhozi	'he's calling your (pl.)/our names'
udzi	'his/her name is being called'
hodzi	'their names are being called'

Writing practice

The following words will be dictated to you. Write what you hear.

_____	_____	'he walked past them'
_____	_____	'I walked past them'
_____	_____	'you walked past them'
_____	_____	'we (du.) walked past them'
_____	_____	'you (du.) walked past them'
_____	_____	'we walked past them'
_____	_____	'they (du.) walked past them'
_____	_____	'they walked past them'

c'- something

One fairly common prefix is **c'**- 'something, someone'. It refers to something or someone possibly known to but not specified by the speaker. **c'**- is a prefix to nouns, verbs and postpositions. In all cases, **c'**- becomes **c'i-** before a consonant.

With nouns, **c'**- 'something's, someone's' is a possessive prefix. In Witsuwit'en, some nouns (usually body parts and relatives) must have a possessor in order to be used in a sentence. In the dictionary, such nouns are preceded by a hyphen to show that they must have a possessor. If a possessor is not known or if the speaker chooses not to specify the possessor, then **c'i-** is added to such nouns.

-ilhtsen 'brother'	bilhtsen 'his/her brother'	c'ilhtsen 'someone's brother'
-c'e' 'belongings'	bic'e' 'his/her belongings'	c'ic'e' 'someone's belongings'
-t'ak 'back'	bit'ak 'his/her back'	c'it'ak 'something's back (e.g. animal)'

Nouns that begin with **u** (there are not many of these), change **u** to **o** after **c'**-. Compare:

uzi 'a name'

buzi' 'his/her name'

c'ozi' 'someone's name'

c'- 'something's, someone's' can be preceded by another layer of possessive prefixes to indicate repossession:

bits'in 'his/her/its bone'

c'its'in 'a bone, something's bone'

bic'its'in 'his/her bone (from another creature)'

sc'its'in 'my bone (from another creature)'

c'- 'something, someone' is also an object of postposition prefix. Compare the following:

yilh yelhdic

'he/she is talking to him/her'

c'ilh yelhdic

'he/she is talking to something, someone'

yibe c'ilht'agh

'he/she is drumming for him/her'

c'ibe c'ilht'agh

'he/she is drumming for someone'

yika'it'ah

'he/she is hunting/trapping for it'

c'ika'it'ah

'he/she is hunting/trapping (for something)'

bika'wenšzin

'I don't want him/her/it'

c'ika'wenšzin

'I don't want anything'

c'- 'something, someone' as direct object prefix on verbs occurs in the same place as the other direct objects,⁴ to the left of the outer subjects:

yitsēlh 'he/she is chopping it'	c'itsēlh 'he/she is chopping something'
ts'itsēlh 'we're chopping it'	c'its'itsēlh 'we're chopping something'
yidīts'agh 'he/she hears, understands him/her'	c'idīts'agh 'he/she hears something'
ts'idīts'agh 'we hear, understand him'	c'izdīts'agh 'we hear, understand someone'
īs'ēn 'I see him/her/it'	c'ēs'ēn 'I see someone, something'
ts'ē'ēn 'we see him/her/it'	c'its'ē'ēn 'we see someone, something'
nielh'ēn 'I'm looking at him/her/it'	c'inieh'ēn 'I'm looking at someone, something' (can also mean 'I'm window-shopping')
ts'inīlh'ēn 'we're looking at him/her/it'	c'iznīlh'ēn 'we're looking at something'

When **c'**- is directly followed by **h**- 'they', it becomes **c'i**-, and then **h**- must drop out because it is between two vowels. Compare:

c'its'it 'he's scratching something'	c'aats'it 'they're scratching something'
c'inīlh'ēn 'he's looking at something'	c'aanīlh'ēn 'they're looking at something'
< c'i-hi-n... --> c'i-i-n... --> c'aan...	

When the verbal prefix **c'i**- is unstressed, it may be easy to confuse with **gi**- 1sg subject prefix. Compare the following:

dic'il'alh	'he/she is feeding him/herself (something)'
digilkwis	'I'm coughing'
nigilggeyh	'I'm running around'
nigilwis	'I'm hot'
bī nic'ildes	'scale' (lit. 'something is weighed by means of it')
bighewh nic'ilt'as to it')	'pattern, template' (lit. 'something is cut according to it')

As you might expect, when the direct object prefix **c'**- precedes **u**, you find **o** instead:

⁴except **y**-, which occurs to the right of the outer subjects.

yuzi	'she's calling his name'
hiyuzi	'they're calling his name'
c'ozī	'she's calling someone's name'
c'oozī	'they're calling someone's name'
<c'i-h-u-zī --> c'i-h-o-zī --> c'i-o-zī --> c'oo-zī	

Writing practice

Here is the formula for the verb 'eat':

_____	_____	_____	'alh
direct object	outer subject	inner subject	root

Remember that tense (**i-** imperfective or **ta-** future) goes in between the outer subject and inner subject positions.

Here are some forms of 'eat' to get you started:

his'alh	'I'm eating it'
c'is'alh	'I'm eating (something)'
tas'ilh	'I'm going to eat it'
c'itas'ilh	'I'm going to eat something'
ts'i'alh	'we're eating it'
c'its'i'alh	'we're eating (something)'
ts'ita'ilh	'we're going to eat it'
c'izta'ilh	'we're going to eat (something)'

Now try to translate and write the remaining forms below:

_____	'eat it, you're eating it'
_____	'eat (something), you're eating (something)'
_____	'you're going to eat it'
_____	'you're going to eat (something)'
_____	'he's eating it'

_____	'he's eating (something)'
_____	'he's going to eat it'
_____	'he's going to eat (something)'
_____	'eat it (you pl.)'
_____	'you (pl.) are eating (something)'
_____	'you pl. are going to eat it'
_____	'you (pl.) are going to eat (something)'
_____	'we (du.) are eating it'
_____	'we (du.) are eating (something)'
_____	'we (du.) are going to eat it'
_____	'we (du.) are going to eat (something)'
_____	'they're eating it'
_____	'they're eating (something)'
_____	'they're going to eat it'
_____	'they're going to eat (something)'

Optative u- ~ o-

Here is some more review from the first literacy class. The optative is the third of the important time categories of Witsuwit'en that we will mention in this set of literacy lessons (the first two we've talked about are imperfective/progressive and future).

The optative is marked by a verb prefix, **o-** or **u-**. Of the pairs of words below, the one on the right is in the optative:

sisde 'I'm sitting'

usde' 'let me sit, I could sit'

his'alh 'I'm eating it'

us'alh 'I could eat it, should I eat it, let me eat it'

c'is'alh 'I'm eating (something)'
(something)'

c'os'alh 'should I eat, let me eat, I could eat

The **o-** form of the optative prefix is used after any of the following consonants:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	'
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

The **u-** form is used after all other consonants and when word-initial. (The optative prefix is deleted after another prefix that ends in vowel.)

The optative is kind of like the subjunctive category of French or Spanish. It is grammatically required when certain other words occur in the sentence, such as the following:

les, lis definite future

usde' les, lis 'I will sit'

wibe 'oondzin 'should'

usde' wibe 'oondzin 'I should sit'

ts'iwelew 'can't, unable'

usde' ts'iwelew 'I can't sit'

gin, ginih 'don't (even)'

unde' gin 'don't sit, don't even think about sitting'

'tell __ to'

usde' silhni 'he told me to sit'

Writing practice

The following words, all optative verb forms, will be dictated to you. Write what you hear.

'I'll see you again'

'I'll see you (pl.) again'

‘we’ll see you again’

‘we’ll see you (pl.) again’

‘let’s (du.) sit there’

‘they (du.) can sit there, let them (du.) sit there’

‘let them sit there’

Writing practice: object of postposition prefixes

The verb 'resemble, look like' takes a postpositional object. Here is the formula for this verb:

_____	-di	_____	u	_____	t'ën
object of postposition	postposition	outer subject	verb prefix	inner subject	root
	'resemble'		'resemble'		'resemble'

Study the forms in the left column. Then translate the English phrases into Witsuwit'en words and right them in the blank.

bidust'ën 'I look like him/her'	_____	'he/she looks like me'
bidudit'ën 'we (du.) look like him/her'	_____	'he/she looks like us'
bidits'ot'ën 'we look like him/her'	_____	'he/she looks like you (sg.)'
bidunt'ën 'you look like him/her'	_____	'you (pl.) look like him/her'
hiydut'ën 'they look like him/her'	_____	'he/she looks like them'
niwhduht'ën 'you (pl.) look like us'	_____	'we look like you (sg.)'
nyidust'ën, ndust'ën 'I look like you (sg.)'	_____	'you (sg.) look like me'
niwhdust'ën 'I look like you (pl.)'	_____	'we (du.) look like you (sg.)'
niwhdudit'ën 'we (du.) look like you (pl.)'	_____	'we (du.) look like them'
niwhdits'ot'ën 'we look like you (pl.)'	_____	'you (pl.) look like me'
sdoot'ën, sidoot'ën 'they look like me'	_____	'I look like them'
hibidoot'ën 'they look like them'	_____	'we look like them'
hibidunt'ën 'you (sg.) look like them'	_____	'they look like you (sg.)'
hibiduht'ën 'you (pl.) look like them'	_____	'they look like you (pl.)'